The birth pangs of Modi 3.0 are now all but settled, so the government can get down to brass tacks in right earnest. What are the challenges it faces in 2025? They go beyond electoral politics, or merely securing its bolts further with the Delhi and Bihar assembly polls due this year. If Narendra Modi's first term was about laying down a futuristic grid, and the second ticked all the Hindutva boxes, he must orient his historic third term towards securing reforms and equitable growth, with jobs as top priority. That will be the best tribute to the Republic in its 75th year. But the passage won't be smooth. Firstly, Donald Trump, in his second coming at the White House, promises to be the "wrecker-in-chief" of the gross national happiness for many countries. India, too, is on his hit list. He has called us the 'Tariff King' in the past. Also expect the compounded H1B visa + illegal immigration row to turn volatile amidst a xenophobic wave in the US.

But there's also a whole lode of silver in that cloud. In Trump's "demolition drive" lies the chance for India to position itself as the main port of call for capital in flight from China. This is the X-factor that could enable us to step on the growth pedal, shedding the sluggishness of the first half of FY25. Especially if we wish to grow out of that dismal K-shape and evolve pathways for the deep growth we need. Here, INDIA TODAY's annual bouquet of essays from eminent names and domain experts helps us reconnoitre all the possible landscapes that lie ahead, global as well as domestic.



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In an illuminating lead essay, former national security advisor Shivshankar Menon says the seeming chaos that envelops us may actually contain the seeds of transformative creativity. "This is now a world between orders," he writes, and appends his reassuringly promising argument: throughout history, a global order has been an exception and periods of alleged instability have always fuelled innovation. The coming Trump era is for him only a symptom of deep structural flux. One that gives India a chance to be a true pillar, rather than just a prop, on the world stage.

Many essayists identify Trump 2.0 as the main imponderable nations like India have to contend with. Axis Bank chief economist Neelkanth Mishra reads the incoming US president's promise to disrupt the status quo as only a "starting point for negotiation". Like Menon, he says striking a win-win deal with Trump will be critical for growth even as India swims through a likely phase of currency fluctuations. University of Vermont professor Pablo Bose charts the uncertainty faced by Indian immigrants in the US—3 million legal, over half a million illegal, plus 250,000 students.

An aggressive China always beeps red on India's radar. Swedish journalist-author Bertil Lintner anticipates a spell of "unpredictable" behaviour from Beijing as well, saying the Belt and Road Initiative has become a bleeding white elephant it's trying to dismount. For author-academic Amita Batra, the intensifying 'China Plus One' phase is the right time for India to ease its own tariff regimes, if it is not to lose out to fast emerging economies like Vietnam. Former foreign secretary Vijay Gokhale looks beyond the border conflict rhetoric that dominates India-China ties to the reality of interdependence. Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa bridges the geopolitical and the political contexts within which India must accomplish its objectives.

Chief among our internal challenges, medical pioneer Naresh Trehan notes a disturbing shift in India's health scan. Past tasks like immunisation are met, but we have a new emergency: non-communicable 'lifestyle' diseases. These cause 66 per cent of all deaths now, up from 45 per cent in 2000. India will need to create five times more physicians by 2047 to cope. In education, ex-Delhi University vice-chancellor Dinesh Singh bats for a need-based, solution-oriented pedagogy to produce a real knowledge economy. Else, he says, even our IT sector runs more on "brawn" than brain power. Scholar Yamini Aiyar brings a sophisticated critical lens to freebies, reading them as a dubious shortcut to genuine rights-based social spending. On gender inequities, economist Ashwini Deshpande scotches the naïve 'statistical' idea of women being unwilling to take up employment with first-hand facts from the field. They just need work closer home, where they bear 10x the burden of chores. Academic Hilal Ahmed records a troubling trend: the "Hindu-Muslim binary" has actually intensified post a general election that "was seen as an ideological defeat of radical Hindutva". Jyoti Deshpande, head of Jio Studios, logs a more uplifting thought: technology is ushering in a "golden age of Indian storytelling" in many tongues.

Then there are universals that affect all: immigrant or native-born, man or woman, Hindu or Muslim. Global warming has already crashlanded on India with extreme, debilitating weather disturbances. Climate expert Navroz K. Dubash flags India's pledge to the future: decarbonisation at home, advocacy for the global south abroad. Former Hyundai India president B.V.R. Subbu surveys a sub-field here: the evolving and doubt-ridden Electric Vehicle landscape. Artificial Intelligence, too, will touch everyone: digital expert Jaspreet Bindra hails the imminence of 'Agentic AI', where Big Data will become your own little Jeeves, booking your vacation, on your preferred flight, with your favourite pizza! Bon voyage and Happy New Year.

(Aroon Purie)